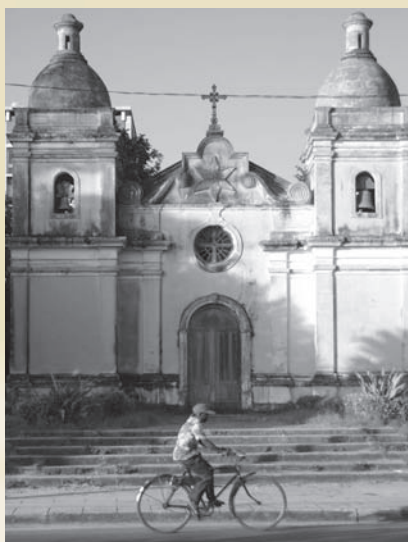




Portuguese legacy

An elegant cathedral in Quelimane is a relic of Portuguese colonial rule. Portuguese is the official language of Mozambique. The most common local dialect is Chuabo.

1990 Renamo loses the support of South Africa as apartheid ends, and in 1994, the ANC—Frelimo supporters—takes power.

1992 Chissano signs Rome peace agreement with Renamo.

1994 Democratic elections return Frelimo to power. They introduce major reforms to modernize the economy.

1995 Mozambique joins the Commonwealth, the only non-British former colony to be a member.

1997 The G7 group of major industrial countries chooses Mozambique as the flagship for its international debt-relief initiative.

2000–01 Devastating floods displace many thousands of people and harm the economy. The country is then affected by a severe drought in 2002.

2004 Armando Guebuza wins presidential election for Frelimo.

2007 Chinese president Hu Jintao visits and promises massive investment.

2009 President Guebeza is reelected with over 75 percent of the vote. The opposition party Renamo alleges fraud.

2010 Riots against food prices break out. Police shoot a number of protesters dead.

Madagascar



One of the world's poorest countries, which won independence from France in 1960.

400s The first settlers arrive from Indonesia. They are later joined by Bantu migrants from Africa.

1500 Portuguese explorer Diego Dias visits Madagascar.

1883–85 The first Franco-Malagasy war leads to the establishment of a French protectorate.

1895 The French invade and capture the main city of Antananarivo.

1896 Madagascar becomes a French colony. The Merina monarchy that rules the interior of the island is abolished as the French subdue the island.

1898–1906 A revolt against French rule is brutally suppressed.

1947–48 French troops kill thousands in nationalist uprisings.

1960 Independence from France.

1975 Radical socialist Didier Ratsiraka takes power. A new constitution sets up a “Democratic Republic” in which only a single party is permitted from 1977.

1990–92 After months of unrest and mass strikes, a new democratic constitution is established that sets up the Third Republic, restores civilian rule, and introduces multi-party democracy.

1991 Opposition Forces Vives (CFV), coalition of political parties, is set up, led by Albert Zafy.

1993 Zafy's CFV defeats Ratsiraka's coalition government in free elections.

1996 Zafy impeached.

1997 Ratsiraka elected president.

1998 New constitution is adopted.

2002 Opposition leader Marc Ravalomanana claims victory in the 2001 presidential election. In response, the incumbent president, Didier Ratsiraka, sets up a rival government in the port city of Tamatave. As fighting breaks out, the High Court rules in Ravalomanana's favor and Ratsiraka goes into exile.

2003 Ratsiraka sentenced in absentia to ten years' hard labor for embezzlement.

2006 Ravalomanana wins reelection.

2008 Cyclone Ivan leaves over 300,000 homeless.

2009 Violent protests in Antananarivo after closure of opposition TV station. The government dismisses Andry Rajoelina, mayor of Antananarivo, and the military mutiny in favor of him. After a standoff, President Ravalomanana resigns and is replaced by Rajoelina.

2009 A power-sharing deal between two sides is brokered, but breaks down.

2010 AU and EU impose sanctions against Madagascar. Ex-president Ravalomanana is sentenced to life imprisonment for the shooting of protesters.

Comoros



An archipelago republic off the east coast with a chaotic political system and frequent coups.

1886 Comoros becomes a French protectorate after years of rule by a matrilineally inherited sultanate with strong cultural ties to the Arab world.

1947 Comoros acquires the status of a French overseas territory.

1961 Internal self-government.

1974 Referendum for independence. Island of Mayotte votes to remain French.

1975 Independence from France.

1975–96 French mercenary Bob Denard overthrows four governments.

1992 Chaotic first multi-party polls.

1997 Both Anjouan and Mohéli islands declare independence.

2002 President Azzali Assoumani, who seized power in 1999, promises a “Union of the Comoros,” but tensions continue.

2006 Muslim cleric Ahmed Abdallah Sambi wins federal presidential elections.

2007 Anjouan president Bacar refuses to stand down; the island effectively secedes.

2008 AU and Comoros troops invade Anjouan and retake it.

2009 Mayotte votes to integrate with France in a referendum not recognized by the Comoran government.

Mauritius



An island republic in the Indian Ocean and one of the world's most densely populated countries.

1598 Mauritius colonized by the Dutch.

1722 First French settlers arrive.



Port Louis

This 18th-century picture shows a view of Port Louis, Mauritius, which was founded by the French in 1735 as a supply port for European ships making the long voyage around the Cape of Good Hope.

1814 Islands acquired by the British.

1968 Independence from Britain.

1992 Becomes a republic.

2000 Coalition government set up that alternates the main parties in power.

Seychelles



A group of 115 islands in the Indian Ocean that have been independent since 1976.

1742 The islands are explored by France, which claims possession of them in 1756.

1770 The first French settlers arrive to exploit the abundant supplies of tortoises and timber; they later introduce slavery.

1814 The Treaty of Paris transfers control of the islands from France to Britain.

1903 Seychelles becomes a crown colony.

1964 Political parties formed, led by France Albert René (pro-independence) and James Mancham (pro-UK rule).

1965 The Desroches, Aldabra, and Farquhar island groups are leased to the US; the British return the islands upon independence in 1976.

1976 Independence from Britain: coalition formed with Mancham as president and René as prime minister.

1977 René takes over in a coup.

1979 One-party socialist rule established.

1979–87 Several coup attempts.

1993 Democratic elections are held for the first time since 1976; René remains president as head of the Seychelles People's Progressive Front (SPPF).

1998 René's SPPF adopts plans for an international trading zone with free ports.

2004 René's vice president, James Michel, assumes the presidency (reelected 2006).